

Past Simple vs Past Perfect

CEFR B1

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

Both are past tenses. Use the past perfect for the earlier action:

- 1 Past simple for the main past events — She arrived at eight.
- 2 Past perfect for something that happened before them — The meeting had already started.

Two past actions: the earlier one is the past perfect, the later one the past simple. If the order is already clear, the past simple is often enough.

At a glance

	Past Simple	Past Perfect
When	the main past event	before another past event
Order	the later action	the earlier action
Example	I got home.	Everyone had left .

Learning objectives

- Can use the past perfect for the earlier of two past actions and the past simple for the later (CEFR B1).
- Can avoid the past perfect where the order is already clear.
- Can interpret the meaning difference between past simple and past perfect in when-clauses.



Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Past Simple vs Past Perfect · CEFR B1

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. When I got to the station, the train ____.

- | | |
|----------------|-------------|
| A. left | B. had left |
| C. was leaving | D. leaves |

2. She ____ the door and ____ in.

- | | |
|--------------------------|------------------|
| A. had opened / had gone | B. opened / went |
| C. was opening / went | D. opens / goes |

3. He was hungry because he ____ breakfast.

- | | |
|------------------|-----------------|
| A. didn't eat | B. hadn't eaten |
| C. wasn't eating | D. doesn't eat |

4. By the time we arrived, the party ____.

- | | |
|-------------|------------------|
| A. finished | B. had finished |
| C. finishes | D. was finishing |

5. I locked the door before I ____.

- | | |
|----------------|----------|
| A. had left | B. left |
| C. was leaving | D. leave |

6. They had ____ dinner before we arrived.

- | | |
|----------|-----------|
| A. ate | B. eaten |
| C. eated | D. eating |

7. 'When I called, she had gone out' means she went out ____.

- | | |
|-------------------|-----------------------|
| A. after my call | B. before my call |
| C. during my call | D. because of my call |

8. I recognised him at once — we ____ once before.

- | | |
|---------|-----------------|
| A. met | B. had met |
| C. meet | D. were meeting |

9. Rewrite with the same meaning: 'They finished the project. Then the boss arrived.'

- | | |
|--|--|
| A. When the boss arrived, they had finished the project. | B. When the boss arrived, they finished the project. |
| C. The boss arrived before they finished. | D. They finished after the boss arrived. |

10. First I ____ up, then I ____ to work.

- | | |
|-----------------------|---------------|
| A. had got / had gone | B. got / went |
| C. was getting / went | D. get / go |

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **B. had left** — The earlier action (leaving first) takes the past perfect: 'had left'.
2. **B. opened / went** — A simple sequence of events takes the past simple: 'opened / went'.
3. **B. hadn't eaten** — The earlier reason takes the past perfect: 'hadn't eaten'.
4. **B. had finished** — 'By the time' + an earlier action takes the past perfect: 'had finished'.
5. **B. left** — With 'before', the order is clear, so the past simple is enough: 'left'.
6. **B. eaten** — After 'had' use the participle: 'eaten' (eat → ate → eaten).
7. **B. before my call** — 'Had gone out' happened before the call.
8. **B. had met** — An action earlier than another past action takes the past perfect: 'had met'.
9. **A. When the boss arrived, they had finished the project.** — The finishing came first, so it's the past perfect: 'had finished'.
10. **B. got / went** — A simple sequence takes the past simple: 'got / went'.